

Standalone Sentence-final Particles: A Cross-linguistic Study of Japanese *ne* and Sichuan Mandarin *ga*

Tao XIE

Version 1

Abstract:

This paper develops a phase-based analysis of so-called Standalone SFP constructions in Japanese and Sichuan Mandarin, arguing that they are derived via PF deletion of the complement of sentence-final particles within a restricted transfer domain. I propose a no-interphasal string deletion condition, according to which deletion must be confined within a single transfer domain; cross-phase deletion is therefore ruled out due to computational inefficiency at the SM interface. Under this approach, particles such as Japanese *ne* and Sichuan Mandarin *ga* are analyzed as heads of AddrP, a phase head, allowing their complements to be fully elided and yielding Standalone Response and Standalone Gap patterns. By contrast, SFPs such as Japanese *yo* and Sichuan Mandarin *sae* are analyzed as non-phasal Commit heads, whose complements span multiple phase domains, resulting in illicit deletion. The analysis is further extended to related PF ellipsis phenomena, including VP-ellipsis, sluicing, argument ellipsis, and CP-as-argument deletion, thereby providing a unified account of cross-construction ellipsis patterns.

Keywords: SFP; PF-deletion; Japanese; Sichuan Mandarin; Phase domain

1. Introduction

Eastern Asia languages share an important discourse feature that many of them employ sentence-final particles (SFP hereafter) to augment discourse-related meanings to an event or proposition. The specific distributions or performative functions may vary in different languages, SFPs normally encode speaker/addressee-orientation, assertion, probability and many others. In Japanese, SFPs like *ne* and *yo* have been extensively studied in the literature and it is generally accepted that they are addressee-oriented and speaker-oriented respectively, often associated with left periphery (in the sense of Rizzi's 1997 split-CP approach) or a dedicated discourse act projection high in syntax.

Particularly, *ne* is commonly taken to be an agreement-seeking particle (see Kinsui 1993, Tanaka 2000, Onodera 2004, among many others) that signals the speaker's presumption of mutual knowledge of the present topic and invites confirmation from the addressee. The example in (1) illustrates a very canonical use of *ne*, where it ends the sentence¹:

- (1) Hanako-wa kasikoi ne.
 Hanako-top smart NE
 'Hanako is smart, right?'

There is another frequently used SFP (probably not as frequently as *ne*), *yo*, that contrasts with *ne* in that it denotes cognitive confrontation rather than mutual knowledge (see, for example, Masuoka 1991). To instantiate this idea, observe the following example, in which the speaker is suggesting that the addressee either does not know or does not agree with the statement.

- (2) Hanako-wa kasikoi yo.
 Hanako-top smart YO
 'Hanako is smart (in case you don't know)!'

Regarding the syntactic properties of *ne* and *yo*, it is possible for them to form a stacked construction, in which *ne* always takes a higher position. As shown in (3-4), *yo* preceding *ne* would lead to ungrammaticality, thus, it seems feasible to assume that *ne* and *yo* are hierarchically distributed:

- (3) Hanako-wa kasikoi yo ne.
 Hanako-top smart YO NE
 'Hanako is smart (in case you don't know), right?'
- (4) *Hanako-wa kasikoi ne yo.
 Intended: 'Hanako is smart, right (in case you don't know)?'

In addition to the pragmatic and syntactic differences between *ne* and *yo* presented above, they also exhibit a less discussed but rather significant characteristic: only *ne*, but not *yo*, can surface standalone. In example (5), it is natural for the addressee to respond with a single *ne* to express agreement or mutual knowledge. However, *yo*, together with many other SFPs in Japanese, fails to do so, and I call this special use of *ne* as Standalone Response (SR).

- (5) Speaker: Hanako-wa kaze-o hii-ta.
 Hanako-top cold-acc catch-pst
 'Hanako is under the weather.'
- Addressee: Ne (*yo/wa/no/ze).

¹ In fact, *ne* can be used in many distinct contexts where it merely functions as a phonetic filler or attention-drawing marker. Although those uses of *ne* fall outside the scope of the current paper, I will briefly address this issue in Section 3.2.

NE
'That's true.'

There is another standalone use of *ne* that excludes all the other SFPs including *yo*. As demonstrated in (6), it is possible to place a *ne* right after an utterance with an explicit phonological stop before it. Pragmatically, this use of *ne* has a stronger force in seeking the agreement from the addressee, who is supposed to respond with an affirmative. By contrast, the speaker in (1) does not necessarily expect any response. I term this use of *ne* Standalone after Gap (SG).

- (6) Hanako-wa kaze-o hii-ta Σ Ne (*yo/wa/no/ze)!
Hanako-top cold-acc catch-pst NE
'Hanako is under the weather. Right?!' (Σ stands for phonological stop)

Quite interestingly, although both the SR and SG uses of *ne* are absent in Standard Mandarin Chinese, a striking parallel can be found in Sichuan Mandarin (hereafter SM), which is a southwestern dialect of Mandarin that shares partial mutual intelligibility with Standard Mandarin (it would be difficult, if not impossible, for speakers of Standard Mandarin to extensively understand Sichuan Mandarin, whereas speakers of Sichuan Mandarin typically would have no trouble comprehending Standard Mandarin, because, as the name suggests, it is the standardized official language). See examples (7-8), it is obvious that the SFP *ga* parallels Japanese *ne* in terms of both structural restrictions and pragmatic interpretations.

- (7) Ta laohér ganmao-lo ga².
(s)he father cold-asp GA
'His father is under the weather, right.'
- (8) Ta laohér ganmao-lo Σ ga (*sae/dema/ha/do/so).
(s)he father cold-asp GA
'His father is under the weather, right?!'
- (9) Speaker: Ta laohér ganmao-lo.
(s)he father cold-asp
'His father is under the weather.'
- Addressee: Ga (*sae/dema/ha/do/so).
GA
'That's right.'

In effect, (1) and (5–6) perfectly align with the SM data in (7-9). Specifically, (7) is the canonical use of *ga*, which resembles what is shown in (1) (i.e., ensuring mutual knowledge or seeking agreement). The use of *ga* in (8) reiterates the SG use of *ne* in that after a phonological stop, many other SFPs are allowed, while the speaker becomes more likely

² As to the romanization of SM, I use a modified *pinyin* system for expository purpose. I will not use IPA because this paper is not about phonology and in the assistance of the modified *pinyin* system for SM, readers who roughly know how *pinyin* works would easily picture the actual pronunciation of SM.

to seek a response from the addressee. Finally, (9) is fully consistent with the Japanese data in (5) that *ga*, but not many other SFPs, can have SR use.

Despite all the similarities shown above, there is one difference between Japanese SFPs and SM SFPs: SM does not allow the stacking of SFPs, which makes it slightly more difficult to determine their structural position:

- (10)*Huahua hen congminsae ga.
Huahua very smart SAE GA
Intended: ‘Huahua is smart (in case you don’t know), right?’

Pan (2021) argues that Standard Mandarin allows the stacking of SFPs, but this is not the case for SM. The ill-formed example in (10) marks this property of SM, as *sae*—the equivalent of Japanese *yo*—fails to cooccur with *ga*. In fact, all the native informants (including me, who barely spoke any Standard Mandarin before 24 years old) find it unacceptable for SFPs to co-occur no matter which two of them in whatever order. I will return to this issue in Section 3, claiming both SM and Japanese are properly accounted for by the above CP framework postulated in Miyagawa (2020).

Previous studies have extensively examined the pragmatic function and syntactic position of SFPs, but have in general assumed that such particles take a fully spelled-out propositional complement. As a result, the relatively rare standalone use of particles like *ne* and *ga* would constitute a piece of linguistic idiosyncrasy that remains outside the prevalent theory for SFPs.

This paper argues that the behaviors of *ne* and its counterpart *ga* in SM are best understood as an instance of discourse-driven ellipsis. Specifically, I propose that SFPs like *ne* and *ga* are the head of Addr(essee)P which is also a phase head above CP. The Standalone SFPs construction stems from the PF-deletion of a phase complement guaranteed by discourse anaphora constructed via interface-initiated access (i.e., the Identity Condition).

This analysis accounts for the standalone use of *ne*-like particles while also explaining the contrast with *yo*-like particles, which require their propositional argument to be accessed by both Conceptual-Intentional (CI) and Sensorimotor (SM) interfaces.

The organization of this paper is as follows: Section 2 presents additional linguistic data for SM particles, showing that they are proper SFPs just like their counterparts in Standard Mandarin and Japanese. In Section 3, I will review a number of related previous studies. In Section 4, I will present a thorough analysis and propose that the standalone use of *ne* and *ga* receives identical treatment. Section 5 concludes the paper.

2. Additional linguistic data of SFPs in SM

Being a sub-branch dialect of Mandarin, SM, especially in its syntactic properties, is much

less studied than Standard Mandarin. The reason is also very simple: other than phonological distinctions and lexical items, it basically has nothing different from Standard Mandarin syntactically. Some of the most well-established findings about Mandarin Chinese can also be found in SM, such as *wh*-in situ, A-not-A constructions and unselective binding into *wh*-operators (see Huang 1982; Tsai 1999; Huang et al. 2009). When it comes to SFPs, although SM differs greatly from Standard Mandarin in lexical specifications, I will next show SFPs in SM instantiate the same type of grammatical object as those in Japanese.

First, SFPs in SM also participate in the encoding of clause type, suggesting that they are not just discourse ornaments. This is exemplified by the following sentences:

- | | |
|--|--------------------------------|
| <p>(11). Ngi yao zuazi o?
 you will do-what O
 ‘What do you want to do?’</p> | <p>Sichuan Mandarin</p> |
| <p>(12). Nani suru no?
 what do NO
 ‘What do you want to do?’</p> | <p>Japanese</p> |

Note that in both languages not only *wh*-phrases stay in situ, but also SFPs designated only for interrogatives are involved. Japanese *no* occur in either polar or *wh*-interrogative, but *o* in SM can only emerge in the latter. In polarity interrogatives, it is *so*, instead of *o*, yielding correct output. Still, the clause-typing function is evident.

The next feature that SFPs in SM share with Japanese SFPs is root phenomena. In both languages, SFPs are not allowed in an embedded environment. In (13-14), in the presence of a matrix verb, embedded SFPs are completely ruled out.

- | | |
|--|--------------------------------|
| <p>(13). *Ngo xiangxiaode [ta zou-lo so].
 I wonder (s)he leave-asp SO
 Intended: ‘I wonder if he’s left.’</p> | <p>Sichuan Mandarin</p> |
| <p>(14). *[Kare-ga ki-ta ne] to sitteir-u.
 he-nom come-pst NE comp know-prs
 Intended: ‘I know that he came.’</p> | <p>Japanese</p> |

Moreover, just like in Japanese, SFPs in SM display strict selectional requirements: they obligatorily attach to a fully projected clausal spine (TP/FinP) and are excluded from subclausal domains. This strongly suggests that they are not adjunct-like discourse elements, but rather functional heads in the left periphery that select a propositional complement, as shown in (15–16).

- | | |
|---|--------------------------------|
| <p>(15)a. Yohan zou-lo sae.
 John leave-asp SAE
 ‘(I believe) John has left.’</p> | <p>Sichuan Mandarin</p> |
|---|--------------------------------|

- | | | | | | |
|--------|---|---------------|----------------------|------|-------------------------|
| b. | Yohan (*sae) | zou-lo (*sae) | liangtian | sae. | Sichuan Mandarin |
| | John | leave-asp | two-days | SAE | |
| | '(I believe) John has left for 2 days.' | | | | |
| (16)a. | John-wa | it-ta | ne. | | Japanese |
| | John-top | go-pst | NE | | |
| | 'John has left, right.' | | | | |
| b. | *John-wa | ne | it-ta ³ . | | Japanese |
| | John-top | NE | go-pst | | |

On top of the SFP status regarding syntactic properties discussed above, SFPs in SM also align with Japanese SFPs in that they do not intervene in the propositional content of a given clause. As mentioned in the Introduction, SFPs are only supposed to add discourse-related meaning; therefore, it is expected that SFPs in SM leave truth conditions unaltered but tweak the speech act or discourse effect. This fact is reflected in every example given above from (11–16).

While the syntactic literature on Sichuan remains limited, the parallels drawn here with Japanese SFPs are not merely impressionistic. Rather, they reflect a shared cluster of grammatical properties, including strict clause-final distribution, selectional dependency on propositional structure, and sensitivity to speech-act distinctions. The present discussion is sufficient to establish that Sichuan SFPs occupy a syntactic status on a par with their Japanese counterparts, thereby paving the way for subsequent discussion.

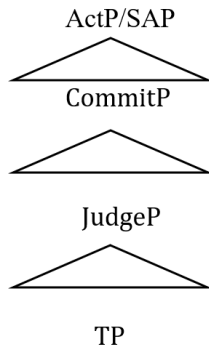
3. Reviews of Previous studies

3.1 Syntax in the Treetops: Miyagawa (2022)

The present work adopts the theoretical framework proposed by Miyagawa (2022). In this approach, based on the evidence supporting the representation of the speaker and the addressee in the superordinate structure (cf. Speas and Tenny 2003 Speech-act Phrase), Miyagawa integrates the Speaker-Addressee Phrase (SAP) into the very top of a left-periphery structure. This SAP projection not only marks the existence of the participants of a dialogue, but also encodes its illocutionary force. In addition, to bridge SAP with the CP domain, Miyagawa takes a slight departure from Krifka (2020) by positing an intermediate Commit(ment)P. According to Krifka, the superordinate layer takes the form of the following structure:

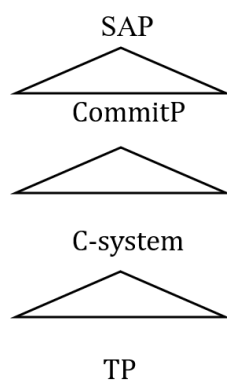
(17).

³ (16b) could be acceptable if *ne* is construed as an attention-drawing marker, which is not the SFP *ne* discussed in this paper (see Usami 1997) because such *ne* does not entail mutual knowledge or seeking agreement.



According to Miyagawa (2022), JudgeP is absorbed by an extended CP system. One of the reasons he does so is that it is suggested that the fusion of JudgeP and CP is a robust move in semantic terms: in contrast to SAP and CommitP, which in principle should not be able to interact with propositional content, JudgeP, on the other hand, may express judgmental comments on a proposition, such as with adverbs like *probably*. Thus, it is not considered part of the expressive component. Therefore, Miyagawa implements a three-layered structure depicted below:

(18).

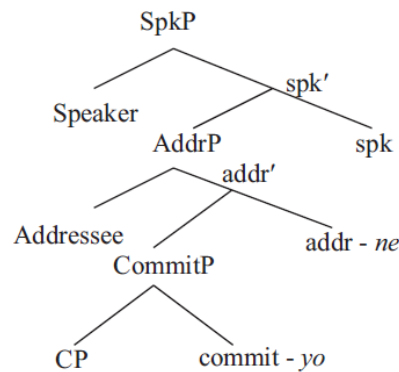


The SAP at the top of the structure consists of two maximal projections, namely SpeakerP and AddresseeP, and I will return to the details in Section 3 when addressing the hierarchical relation between SFPs and vocatives. It is of particular interest that Miyagawa (2022, Ch. 3) explicitly argues for the structure of Japanese SFPs. For *ne*—the addressee-

oriented particle—he proposes that it occupies the head of AddresseeP, whose specifier hosts the representation of the addressee. As for *yo*, he contends that it is an amplifier of commitment occupying the head position of CommitP. The structural distinction between the two SFPs is illustrated as follows:

(19).

extracted from Miyagawa (2022: 105)



The structure in (19) not only correctly captures the hierarchical relation between the two SFPs, but also neatly represents their semantic/discourse properties. To conclude, Miyagawa presents a layered superordinate structure in which distinct SFPs are hosted, which may provide a well-established theoretical framework for the present work. I will show in the following sections that the structure in (19) is the key to the solution of the standalone SFPs shown previously.

3.2 Which *ne* are we talking about: Nakamura (2006)

Many researchers have already noticed that *ne* is probably the most versatile SFP in Japanese because it can induce numerous pragmatic ambiguities. Thus, it is my responsibility to clarify which kind of *ne* the present work focuses on.

Nakamura (2006) systematically argues that *ne* has three uses, which can be paraphrased as follows:

- (20)
- a. *ne* applied to contentive domain= reciprocal effect
 - b. *ne* applied to cognitive domain= confirmation of the utterance
 - c. *ne* applied to utterance action domain= speaker-oriented

In (20a), what is referred to as the reciprocal use of *ne* can be realized through the following conversation, in which *ne* denotes mutual knowledge and seeking agreement, hence it seems unproblematic to treat this use of *ne* as the intended target.

- (21). Customer: ikura des-u ka?
 how.much be-prs Q
 'How much is this?'
 Shop-owner: 600-yen desu ne.
 600-yen be-prs NE
 'That would be 600 yen.' (checking the price tag with the customer)

By using *ne* at the end of an utterance, the shop owner is confirming information with the customer, and such confirmation can be done visually. Thus, the reciprocal use of *ne* can be seen as the canonical one and fall within the scope of the current work.

Next, Nakamura proposes that there is *confirmation of the utterance* use of *ne*. In such cases, *ne* is used when the speaker is not fully confident about his/her utterance, and the addressee's agreement or reconfirmation is sought. See (22):

- (22).Kore-sae ar-eba zyubun da yo ne.
 this-only have-if enough be YO NE
 'As long as we have this, it should be alright.'

However, the speaker-oriented use of *ne* shows obvious inconsistency with the uses of *ne* in (21–22), in that it does not involve any intention to seek agreement. As illustrated in (23–24), *ne* in each of the examples functions as an attention-drawing element and a gap-filler.

- (23).Hanako-wa-ne yuube-ne piza-o-ne tabe-ta. (Miyagawa 2022: 102)
 Hanako-top-NE last.night-NE pizza-acc-NE eat-pst
 'Hanako ate pizza last night.'

- (24).Yuube-wa desu ne. piza-o tabe-ta
 last.night-top be NE pizza-acc eat-pst
 'Last night, I had pizza.'

The use of *ne* in (23) is quite different from the SFP uses shown above, because it can literally show up with any constituent. Miyagawa (2022) also discusses this kind of *ne* and claims it should be distinguished from the SFP use of *ne* for syntactic and semantic reasons (*pace* Saito 2015). Along with the gap-filler use in (24), Nakamura (2006) concludes that reciprocal effect and confirmation-of-utterance uses of *ne* (cf. 21–22) differ from the speaker-oriented *ne* in that the former confirms objective content as differentiated from the common ground, whereas the latter merely confirms a fragment of an utterance, attempting to have the addressee keep up with what the speaker is saying.

At this stage, it is plausible to restrict the target of the present work to the reciprocal effect and confirmation-of-utterance uses of *ne*, because only these uses of *ne* constitute proper SFPs.

3.3 Standalone *ne* and particle stranding ellipsis: Sato (2012)

Japanese allows the ellipsis of a nominal element suffixed by a particle. As observed by Hattori (1960), Particle Stranding Ellipsis (PSE) typically occurs in response to a previous utterance within a dialogue, as shown in (25).

- (25). Speaker A: Taro-wa nani-o tabe-ta?
Taro-top what-acc eat-pst
'What did Taro eat?'
Speaker B: **Wa**-ne, banana-o tabe-ta yo⁴.
top-NE banana-acc eat-pst YO
'He ate banana.'

Aside from the topic marker *wa*, it is also possible for PSE to occur with other particles, such as the case marker *ga* and the modal expression *mitai*, whether-type embedded polar question marker *kadooka*, and C-head *to* (see Sato and Maeda 2019).

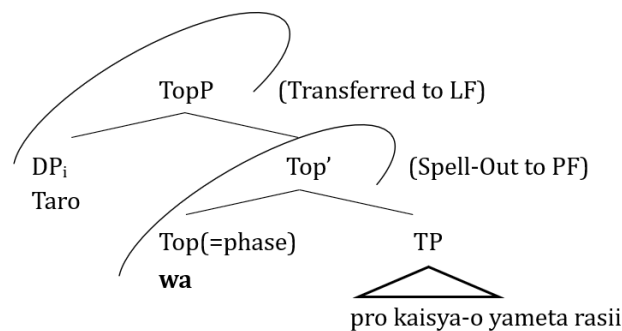
- (26). Speaker A: Taro-ga doo sita no? (Sato and Maeda 2019: 361)
Taro-nom howdo-pst Q
'What did Taro do?'
Speaker B: **Ga** kaisya-o yameta-rasii yo.
acc company-acc quit-seem YO
'Taro seemed to quit his company.'
- (27). Speaker A: Taro-ga ki-ta yo.
Taro-nom come-pst YO
'Taro has come.'
Speaker B: **Mitai** desu ne.
seem be NE
'It seems to be the case.'
Speaker B: **Kadooka**-wa wakari-ma-sen ne.
KADOOKA-top know-plt-neg NE
'I don't know whether he came or not.'
Speaker B: **To** omoi-mas-u.
COMP think-plt-prs
'I think so.'

Sato (2012) proposes a phase-theoretic analysis to account for three crucial properties of the PSE structure, namely, (i) PSE can only apply to a sentence-initial topic element; (ii) PSE is a root phenomenon; (iii) PSE can only apply once per clause. To summarize his

⁴ As discussed in 3.2, the *ne* right after *wa* should not be considered a proper SFP. Formally, it is not located in the final position. Pragmatically, it does not have the expressive content that the real *ne* has (i.e., mutual knowledge and seeking agreement).

analysis, consider the following structure:

(28).



According to Sato (2012), the TopP undergoes a split Transfer. The Top head (*wa*) and its complement are spelled-out to PF for externalization, resulting in a subject-silent PSE construction. The entire TopP is then transferred to LF because the silent subject clearly has a place in the semantic component. Although Sato does not elaborate on the exact nature of “Spell-Out” and “Transfer to LF” therein, I will take the liberty of assuming that they are not different operations by nature. In the current framework of the Minimalist Program (see Chomsky 2013, 2015, 2020; Chomsky et al. 2023, among others), transfer is the operation that links syntactic derivation to the CI and SM interfaces, suggesting that what is later interpreted/externalized should in principle be transferred. Therefore, Sato’s (2012) proposal can be paraphrased to some extent as follows:

(29). *Derivations for PSE*

Syntactic objects can be selectively transferred to SM interface if the interface has already had the access to its discursual antecedent.

Sato’s (2012) analysis successfully accounts for the three properties of PSE, but has some theoretical and empirical shortcomings. As pointed out by Sato and Maeda (2019), Sato’s (2012) optional Spell-Out approach relies on the assumption that a head and its complement are spelled-out together. However, it has generally been accepted since Chomsky (2001) that the output of transfer (to SM in this case) is the complement of a head. Hence, the optional Spell-Out approach invokes an ad hoc theoretical assumption not independently motivated.

Sato (2012) also falls short of empirical coverage. First, as presented above in (26–27), PSE can occur with the nominative case marker *ga* or the modal expression *mitai*, suggesting that there is no uniform functional head licensing PSE.

Building on Sato’s (2012) theoretical and empirical problems, Sato and Maeda (2019) put forward a string-sensitive PF deletion approach for PSE, where the string deletion

proposed by Mukai (2003) for Japanese gapping is taken to be the key to the PSE data presented above. See (30) for the definition of string deletion:

- (30). *String Deletion in the Phonological Component* (adopted from Sato and Maeda 2019: 367)
 String Deletion may apply to a contiguous phonetic string in U_E (elliptical utterance) at PF, regardless of its syntactic constituency, if U_A (antecedent utterance) has the identical phonetic string.

The PSE construction is correctly predicted by string deletion. See example (31), which is taken from Sato and Maeda (2019: 368), and the glosses are mine, with its string deletion–based representation underlined. The string that gets deleted in UE is clearly a contiguous phonological string. The deleted chunk constitutes only part of the syntactic constituents, leaving *mitai* stranded. Most importantly, there is an antecedent utterance that corresponds to what has been elided (i.e., *Chomsky is visiting Japan in March*).

- (31). Speaker A: Chomsky-ga sangatu-ni rainiti-suru-rasii yo
 Chomsky-nom March-dat visit.Japan-do-seem YO
 ‘It seems that Chomsky is visiting Japan in March.’
 Speaker B: **Mitai** desu ne.
 seem be NE
 ‘It seems true.’
 Control: Kare-ga sangatu-ni rainiti-suru-mitai desu ne.
 he-nom March-dat visit.Japan-do-seem be NE
 ‘It seems that he is visiting Japan in March.’

Returning to the standalone SFPs discussed in the Introduction, the string deletion approach seems to be a valid analysis, as it offers a theoretically and empirically well-supported account of the PSE data. However, a potential misunderstanding regarding the nature of string deletion needs to be clarified. Given the definition of string deletion in (30), it should be construed as an application of PF deletion rather than as a licensing condition for it. In other words, “identical phonological string containing verb” does not necessarily license deletion. Let us consider a fragment ellipsis example from English:

- (32). Speaker A: He has eaten 3 pizzas.
 Speaker B: Me (have eaten), four.

Within the U_E of Speaker B, there is no identical phonological string in U_A. Due to agreement mismatch, there is never string identity. Additionally, Sakamoto and Saito (2018) argue that some of the PSE examples fail to be accounted for by string deletion; let us take the *daremo* construction to illustrate this counterargument. In (33), even when there is an identical string in U_A, PSE is ungrammatical.

- (33). Speaker A: [Dare-ga tukut-ta suupu-mo] oisii no?
 who-nom make-pst soup-MO delicious Q

‘Is the soup that everyone made delicious?’
 Speaker B: *Mo oisii yo.
 MO delicious YO
 Intended: ‘The soup that everyone made is delicious.’
 Control: [Dare-ga tukut-ta suupu-mo] oisii yo.
 who-nom make-pst soup-MO delicious YO
 ‘The soup that everyone made is delicious.’

Therefore, I consider String Deletion as a descriptive generalization of certain possible elliptical constructions, but not a licensing condition. Instead, I assume the well-known eGiveness (Merchant 2001) to be the licensing condition for ellipsis. Merchant argues that an expression E can be elided only if it is e-GIVEN with respect to a salient antecedent A. Formally, E counts as e-GIVEN iff, modulo $\exists$ -type shifting, A entails the F-closure of E, and E entails the F-closure of A (Merchant 2001: 26–31). Here, F-closure replaces all F-marked constituents with existentially bound variables of the appropriate type. Following this condition, the fragment ellipsis in (32) can be represented by the existential quantification over variables outlined in (34).

- (34). A: $\exists x, n$ [x has eaten n pizzas]
 E: $\exists x, n$ [x has eaten n pizzas]

Since the two representations in (34) are identical after F-closure, they trivially satisfy the mutual-entailment requirement imposed by e-GIVENness. Therefore, the fragment is correctly predicted to be licit under this analysis. Crucially, this analysis derives the acceptability of the fragment without recourse to phonological string identity, further supporting the view that string deletion is not a licensing condition.

4. Proposals

I propose that the aforesaid standalone SFPs in Japanese and SM can be uniformly accounted for by a modified optional transfer/externalization analysis similar to Sato (2012). To be specific, I argue that SFPs like Japanese *ne* and SM *ga*, which are addressee-oriented particles encoding expressive components such as mutual knowledge and the seeking of confirmation, are the head of AddrP subsumed under SAP (following Miyagawa 2022). I further propose that the Addr head is a phase head in the expressive layer that transfers its complement to interfaces. The superficial standalone SFPs (Standalone Response and Standalone After Gap) presented in (5–6) and (7–9) are the result of PF deletion licensed by the presence of an antecedent utterance at the interfaces and a phase-based condition on the boundary of the deleted string. Crucially, the theoretical and empirical problems of Sato (2012) pointed out by Sato and Maeda (2019) are eliminated.

4.1 Standalone SFPs are not subject to Mukai's 2003 String Deletion

In this subsection, I argue that Standalone SFPs are not the outcome of the application of string deletion (SD). Recall that SD dictates that as long as U_A contains an identical phonological string, it can be elided in U_E . Hence, if one assumes that Standalone SFPs are instances of PF deletion, they would be predicted by SD because the elided portion indeed has an identical string in U_A . Now consider the unelided versions of standalone SFPs illustrated in (35–36).

- (35). Speaker: Hanako-wa kaze-o hii-ta. **Japanese**
 Hanako-top cold-acc catch-pst
 'Hanako is under the weather.'
 Addressee: Ne (*yo/wa/no/ze).
 NE
 'That's true.'
 Control: Hanako-wa kaze-o hii-ta ne.
 Hanako-top cold-acc catch-pst NE
 'It is true that Hanako is under the weather.'
- (36). Ta ganmao-lo ga. **Sichuan Mandarin**
 (s)he cold-asp GA
 'He is under the weather, right?!'
 Control: Ta ganmao-lo. Ta ganmao-lo ga.
 (s)he cold-asp GA
 'He is under the weather, right?!'

As shown in the control sentences above, in both SR and SG examples in SM and Japanese, it is quite natural for the speaker using standalone SFPs to repeat the antecedent utterance before *ne* or *ga*. As for the control in (35), though it sounds somewhat redundant according to some of my informants, it is perfectly acceptable and may be interpreted as a token of honorification. In fact, if the addressee in (35) is inferior to the speaker with respect to social status, it would be offensive or inappropriate to use a standalone *ne*. Rather, repeating the antecedent utterance is the appropriate strategy (the verb should also be in honorific form). In the same vein, there is no awkwardness if a speaker of SM repeats their own utterance before the standalone *ga*, as in the control in (36). Since the elided string is identical to that in U_A and the elided part is contiguous, one should expect standalone SFPs to be governed by SD just like PSE.

However, as I have claimed in Section 3.3, SD should be taken as a descriptive generalization of certain forms of PF deletion, and it is undesirable to treat it as a licensing condition. It might be the case that the data shown in (35–36) are correctly described under an SD-based account, but it should also be capable of accounting for the ellipses in (37–38) as well, contrary to the facts.

- (37). Speaker: Hanako-wa kaze-o hii-ta. **Japanese SR**

- Hanako-top cold-acc catch-pst
 ‘Hanako is under the weather.’
 Addressee: *Yo. (fuku kise-te)
 YO cloth make.wear-imp
 Intended: ‘Of course, she is. Make sure she wears more clothes.’
 Control: Hanako-wa kaze-o hii-ta yo. (fuku kise-te)
 Hanako-top cold-acc catch-pst YO. cloth make.wear-imp
 ‘Of course, Hanako is under the weather. Make sure she wears more clothes.’
- (38). *Hanako-wa kaze-o hii-ta Σ yo. **Japanese SG**
 Hanako-top cold-acc catch-pst YO.
 ‘Of course, Hanako is under the weather.’
 Control: Hanako-wa kaze-o hii-ta. Hanako-wakaze-o hii-ta yo.
 Hanako-top cold-acc catch-pst YO.
 ‘Of course, Hanako is under the weather.’
- (39). Speaker: Ta ganmao-lo. **Sichuan Mandarin SR**
 (s)he cold-asp
 ‘He is under the weather.’
 Addressee: *Ha. (Mo fan ta)
 HA don’t bother (s)he
 Intended: ‘In case you don’t know. Leave him alone!’
 Control: Ta ganmao-lo ha. (Mo fan ta)
 (s)he cold-asp HA don’t bother (s)he
 ‘(In case you don’t know) he is under the weather. Leave him alone!’
- (40). *Ta ganmao-lo Σ ha. Mo fan ta. **Sichuan Mandarin SG**
 (s)he cold-asp HA. don’t bother (s)he
 Intended: ‘(In case you don’t know) he is under the weather. Leave him alone!’
 Control: Ta ganmao-lo. Ta ganmao-lo ha. Mo fan ta.
 (s)he cold-asp HA don’t bother (s)he
 ‘(In case you don’t know) he is under the weather. Leave him alone!’⁵⁷

As the controls in (37–40) demonstrate, SD becomes inactive when SFPs other than *ne* and *ga* are used. In the case of (37–38), despite the acceptability of repeating the antecedent utterance before Japanese *yo*, acceptability drops sharply if the identical string is elided. Similarly, when an utterance in SM ends with *ha*—an SFP that expresses new information the addressee is not aware of—standalone SR or SG use in (39–40) is strictly prohibited.

The sharp contrast depicted in (35–36) and (37–40), together with the striking parallelism between Japanese and SM, challenges the licensing character of SD. Illicit standalone SFPs

⁵ There are multiple meanings of the SFP *ha* in SM. In addition to the make-known use in (38), it may also express a slight uncertainty about a proposition. Either way, it is banned from standalone use in SR or SG.

in (37–40) are predicted to be well-formed ellipses, an undesirable result. Therefore, SD is not the correct analysis for standalone SFPs.

4.2 No Interphasal String Ellipsis

Since SD cannot be the correct analysis, I propose an alternative analysis for standalone SFPs. As briefly discussed at the beginning of Section 4, the transfer-domain-based analysis hinges upon two essential theoretical considerations: (i) the Addr head is a phase head, and PF deletion should not penetrate the phase edge; (ii) what was previously externalized via the SM interface can be optionally ignored by the interface (i.e., the Identity Condition). Next, let us walk through the technical details of this analysis.

4.2.1 The phasehood of SAP

First, I assume that Addr is a phase head. It is assumed in Phase Theory (see Chomsky 2000, 2001, 2004, and 2008) that v^* and C, which represent thematic and propositional structures respectively, count as phase heads. One of the most important representational features of phase heads is the presence of uninterpretable formal features, for example, the $u\varphi$ feature on v^* and the $uQ/u\varphi$ feature on C.

As for the feature inventory of Addr, the existence of formal features seems to be rather limited. Nevertheless, the presence of uninterpretable features may not always mark a phase head. For most East Asian languages, including Mandarin, Japanese, and Korean, etc., it is arguably true that their lexical items are inherently devoid of φ -features, as these languages do not exhibit person agreement. The point is that it would be misleading to conclude that these languages do not employ C and v^* as phase heads, because many phase-driven phenomena would no longer be accounted for. For example, let us suppose that v^* in Japanese is no longer a phase head (see a similar move in Narita and Fukui 2020), because it does not have uninterpretable formal features. The following examples are from Ochi (2004: 65), demonstrating an asymmetry between nominative subject and genitive subject in relative clauses:

- (41) a. Hanako-ga saihu-o nakusi-ta kyositu.
 Hanako-nom purse-acc lose-pst classroom
 ‘The classroom where Hanako lost her purse.’
 b. *Hanako-no saihu-o nakusita kyositu.
 Hanako-gen purse-acc lose-pst classroom
 ‘The classroom where Hanako lost her purse.’

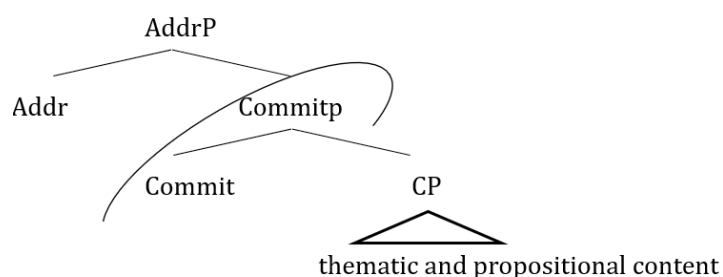
Despite the grammaticality of the nominative subject *Hanako-ga*, the genitive subject is not allowed in relative clauses. Ochi (2004) proposes that the ungrammaticality of (41b) is due to the obligatorily raised object blocking the probe from accessing the DP in a higher phase. Since Japanese is not a φ -agreement language, it cannot be a labeling requirement that drives such movement ($\{XP, YP\}$ structure is expected after object raising). Therefore, I conclude that such obligatory object raising is driven by v^* being a phase head, and if the

object stays in situ, the Phase Impenetrability Condition will bar further movement, leaving the contrast in (41) unexplained.

Then, what is the decisive factor determining a head's phasehood? I propose that phasehood strictly corresponds to semantic entailment. Given the Markovian nature of syntax, no look-ahead or look-back in derivational steps is possible. Therefore, how does syntax determine what counts as a "semantic-chunk-like" domain? Here, I follow the analysis in Xie (2025), which proposes a condition for what constitutes a transfer domain with respect to θ -assignment. In particular, he argues that the assigner and the assignee of a θ -role should be transferred simultaneously, because constructing a thematic domain within a single application of transfer is computationally more efficient than doing so in two applications; as a result, less memory and fewer computational resources are required. In other words, if syntax does not determine the range of a transfer domain, it should in principle be possible for any syntactic object to be transferred at any point. Nonetheless, less computational capacity is required if v^* is taken to be the first phase head: V and its object would form the first transfer domain, and the CI interface is able to construct a thematic relation with a single application of transfer. The same conclusion extends to C: if T, instead of C, is the second phase head, the subject in Spec, TP cannot be interpreted together with the verb, suggesting that an additional application of transfer is required to establish the propositional domain.

Regarding the phasehood of Addr, recall that Miyagawa (2022) claims that SAP and CommitP constitute the expressive component, and CommitP is the projection that links SAP to the proposition (i.e., CP). The current work assumes that Addr, rather than Commit, is the phase head. My defense of this proposal is that CommitP, as stated in Geurts (2019), represents a three-place relation between the speaker, the addressee, and the proposition. If Commit is a phase head and has its complement transferred, a problem of vacuous interpretation arises: what is fed to the interfaces is semantically identical to that of the previous transfer domain, namely the proposition. In other words, an application of transfer contributes nothing new to the interfaces. Instead, if my proposal is on the right track, the complement of Addr gets transferred, and the CI interface would know what the commitment entails, as depicted in (42). After the transfer of CommitP, the remaining SAP may undergo root Spell-Out similar to the standard treatment of Spec, CP.

(42)



4.2.2 Banning Interphasal ellipsis

Now, let us return to the question of what conditions standalone SFPs in Japanese and SM. I follow Miyagawa (2022: cpt. 3), who analyzes *ne* and *yo* in Japanese as the heads of Addr and Commit, respectively. Given the syntactic, semantic, and pragmatic similarity shared by *ga* in SM and *ne*, I propose that *ga* also occurs as the Addr head. Then why do only *ne* and *ga* allow ellipsis of the entire preceding string? I propose the following condition on string ellipsis:

(43) *No Interphasal String Ellipsis*

The ellipsis of a string cannot be extended to more than one transferred domain⁶.

A phase-based theory for ellipsis is not uncommon in the literature (see Tanabe 2025 and references cited therein). I suggest that the theoretical motivation of this condition is similar to the aforementioned characterization of phase heads. Cross-domain ellipsis would force the SM interface to refer back to previously processed syntactic objects, resulting in a waste of computational resources. On top of the assumption that Addr, but not Commit, is a phase head, (43) then provides a direct account of the syntactic idiosyncrasies that standalone SFPs show. Take (35), repeated as (44), as an example:

- (44) Speaker: Hanako-wa kaze-o hii-ta. **Japanese**
 Hanako-top cold-acc catch-pst
 ‘Hanako is under the weather.’
 Addressee: Ne (*yo/wa/no/ze).
 NE
 ‘That’s true.’
 Control: Hanako-wa kaze-o hii-ta ne.
 Hanako-top cold-acc catch-pst NE
 ‘It is true that Hanako is under the weather.’

I have argued that all the instances of Standalone SFPs involve control of the form in (44)⁷, then the condition in (43) correctly predicates that the string of ‘Hanako-wa kaze-o hii-ta’ can delete as a whole. Furthermore, if (43) is defensible, partial deletion within a phase complement should be possible, and this is borne out in the case of Standalone SFPs:

⁶ See Takahashi (2011) for a similar assumption which requires that only phase-complement can undergo ellipsis.

⁷ A potential counterargument to the present proposal is that *ne* in SG formation is not the phonological residue of a full-fledged utterance, but rather a particle contained within the antecedent utterance, with the apparent gap arising from phonetic deletion. I argue that this line of reasoning is misguided. The following example involves two independent instances of *ne*, both of which seek agreement or confirmation. The most plausible conclusion, then, is that the second *ne* originates in a subsequent utterance (i.e., a separate SAP) whose phase complement has been elided.

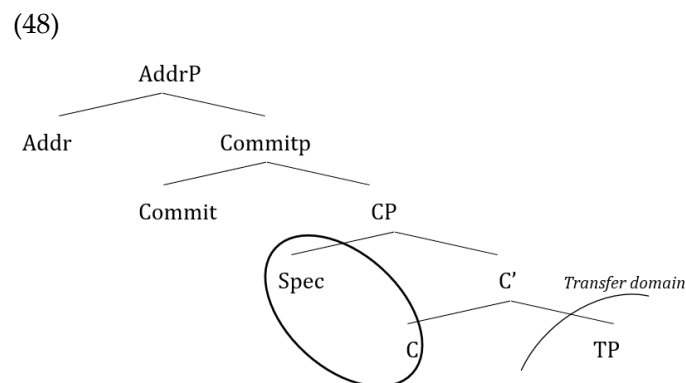
- (i) Kyo-wa atui ne. Σ Ne.
 today-top hot NE NE
 ‘Today is quite hot, huh? Don’t you think so?’

- (45) Speaker: Hanako-wa kaze-o hii-ta. **Japanese**
 Hanako-top cold-acc catch-pst
 ‘Hanako is under the weather.’
 Addressee: Kaze-o ne!
 cold-acc NE
 ‘She got sick, right?’

This observation should extend to the SM data as well. As illustrated in (46–47), this holds for both SR and SG.

- (46) Speaker: Ta ganmao-lo. **SM**
 (s)he cold-asp
 ‘He is under the weather.’
 Addressee: Ta ga.
 (s)he GA
 ‘It him, right?’
- (47) Ta ganmao-lo. (Ta) (ganmao-lo) Ga. **SM**
 (s)he cold-asp (s)he cold-asp GA
 ‘He is under the weather, right?’

The illicit ellipsis involving SFPs such as *yo* can now receive a uniform analysis. As noted above, I adopt Miyagawa’s (2022) proposal that *yo* in Japanese heads CommitP, and, under my proposal in Section 4.2.1, it does not qualify as a phase head. It then follows that string deletion of the type in (48) is ruled out: if deletion applies immediately after the merger of *yo*, the material to be transferred would constitute an interphasal chunk—namely, the complement of C together with its edge (possibly the entire C-domain)—which spans distinct phases, thereby violating (43).



As the diagram in (48) suggests, deletion that leaves Commit dangling is incompatible

with the computation-efficiency-driven condition in (43)⁸. One might instead argue that the material preceding Commit (i.e., Japanese *yo* or SM *sae*) is entirely transferred/deleted at the CP phase; since this transfer domain is confined to a single phase-head complement (i.e., the complement of C), no violation of (43) arises. On this view, once the SAP phase is completed, Spec-CP together with CommitP is transferred for (non-)externalization as the complement of Addr. While this approach appears to circumvent a violation of (43), I will show in Section 4.2.3 that standalone *yo* necessarily entails ellipsis of the CP edge, resulting in interphasal deletion. It also raises a concern regarding computational efficiency: why posit two instances of deletion when one would suffice?⁹ At this point, a natural prediction is that any standalone Commit head gives rise to illicit string deletion. I will further show in the following subsections that non-SAP ellipsis may permit the ‘dangling’ of *yo*-like SFPs, since the deleted material does not extend into the C-edge.

To recap, this subsection proposes a crucial condition requiring that ellipsis be confined to

⁸ According to the restrictions imposed by (43), the SFP *ka* in Japanese, normally taken to be C, should be allowed in Standalone SFP construction as well. However, the grammaticality of this type of deletion varies among native speakers. See the examples in (iii-iv).

- (ii) Speaker: Hanako-wa kaze-o hii-ta.
 Hanako-top cold-acc catch-pst
 ‘Hanako is under the weather.’
 Addressee: ??Ka?
 KA
 ‘Really?’
- (iii) ?Hanako-wa kaze-o hii-ta. Σ Ka?
 Hanako-top cold-acc catch-pst KA
 ‘Hanako is under the weather. I see.’

Both SR and SG uses of *ka* are more acceptable than those of *yo*. However, the SR use illustrated in (iii) is quite marginal and only acceptable in a deliberately stylized utterance. By contrast, the SG use in (iv) turns out to be better, and it is used when the speaker is talking to him/herself if *ka* is defocused prosodically, which might not be the exact same *ka* most studies refer to. I will leave the scrutiny on *ka* open, since its partial (3 out of 5 informants think (iii-iv) are fine) acceptability suffices to support the non-interphasal string condition formalized in (43).

Following this line of reasoning, we should expect question markers in other languages to behave like Japanese *ka*. As a matter of fact, both Standard and Sichuan Mandarin are consistent with this observation:

- (iv) Yinwei fagun chuo-bu-lan dalieba. Σ ma? **Standard Mandarin**
 because baguette poke-not-crumble big.rye bread MA
 ‘Because a baguette can’t pierce through big rye bread?’

The above example is extracted from a video on baguette (https://www.bilibili.com/video/BV1JH4y1c7hP?spm_id_from=333.788.recommend_more_video.1&trac_kid=web_related_0.router-related-2479604-gjmc5.1776389479059.294&vd_source=21b6dbe706ecb3c16ada69bbe10b3ccf, circa 1:22), and the question marker *ma* perfectly displays the SG use of Standalone SFPs. In fact, comparing to the Japanese SG use in (iv), Standard Mandarin SG may even have a rhetorical flavor.

⁹ Following van Craenenbroeck (2010) that ellipsis must have a head to anchor in, I argue if *ne* is not introduced in the syntax, there would be no such anchoring head for deletion. In other words, *yo* must be the anchoring head in Standalone SFPs construction, leading to the undesirable interphasal string.

a single transfer domain; otherwise, additional re-probing of previously transferred material would be necessary, resulting in unnecessary computational cost. In the next subsection, I examine the empirical coverage of the condition in (43) and argue that it constitutes a plausible generalization.

4.2.3 The empirical robustness of the no interphasal condition

It is generally accepted in the literature that VP-ellipsis and sluicing involve deletion of a phase complement (i.e., the complement of v^* and C; see Merchant 2001, 2013, among many others). Here, I present evidence from Japanese showing that a number of PF ellipses can be subsumed under the condition proposed above.

I begin with VP-ellipsis in Japanese. The examples in (49–50) illustrate a contrast with respect to the presence or absence of a light verb. In (49), ellipsis is illicit due to the absence of the light verb *suru*, which leaves the tense affix stranded:

- (49) a. Hanako-wa keitai-o hakai-si-ta.
 Hanako-top cell.phone-acc destroy-do-pst
 ‘Hanako lost her cell phone.’
 b. *Taro-mo (~~keitai-o hakai-si~~) ta.
 Taro-too
 Intended: ‘Taro did too.’
- (50) a. Hanako-wa keitai-o hakai-si-ta.
 Hanako-top cell.phone-acc destroy-do-pst
 ‘Hanako lost her cell phone.’
 b. Taro-mo (~~keitai-o hakai~~) si-ta.
 Taro-too do-pst
 Intended: ‘Taro did too.’

Tanabe (2025: 130) argues that the ungrammaticality of (49) can be attributed to Lasnik’s (1995) Stranded Affix Filter, according to which a bound morpheme such as Japanese *-ta* cannot be left without a host. By contrast, the no-interphasal-ellipsis condition proposed here derives the same result without invoking an additional filter: the ellipsis in (49) encompasses not only the VP but also the silent light verb/phase head v^* , thereby spanning elements from distinct phases. In contrast, the ellipsis in (50b) instantiates genuine VP-deletion, which requires the entire complement of v^* to be deleted, in compliance with (43).

At this point, one might ask how the proposed no-interphasal condition accommodates the licit ellipsis in (51), where only the internal argument of V is deleted —i.e., Argument Ellipsis (AE). Otani and Whitman (1991) argue that AE instantiates VP-ellipsis, whereas subsequent work (e.g., Saito 2007; Takita 2009) treats it as genuine argument ellipsis¹⁰.

- (51) a. Hanako-wa keitai-o hakai-si-ta.

¹⁰ For non-ellipsis analysis, see Oku (1998) and later studies.

- Hanako-top cell.phone-acc destroy-do-pst
 'Hanako lost her cell phone.'
- b. Taro-mo (~~keitai-o~~) hakai-si-ta.
 Taro-too destroy-do-pst
 Intended: 'Taro did too.'

Recall that the no-interphasal condition is formulated for string deletion, since a string spanning multiple phases would give rise to computational redundancy. By contrast, what is deleted in (51) is a constituent rather than a string; irrespective of its timing or transfer domain, it is interpreted/externalized at a unique stage of the derivation. It follows that the condition in (43) is not intended to apply uniformly to all types of PF deletion. In particular, it does not straightforwardly account for the PSE discussed in Section 3, as the standard implementation of PSE involves the deletion of a single constituent.

However, the no-interphasal condition may account for the ungrammatical string-eliding PSE in Japanese in (33), repeated here as (52), where the material to which *mo* attaches is deleted. By contrast, particles such as *mitai*, *kadooka*, and *to* appear to permit such PSE, as illustrated in (27), repeated as (53).

- (52). Speaker A: [Dare-ga tukut-ta suupu-mo] oisii no?
 who-nom make-pst soup-MO delicious Q
 'Is the soup that everyone made delicious?'
- Speaker B: ***Mo** oisii yo.
 MO delicious YO
 Intended: 'The soup that everyone made is delicious.'
- (53). Speaker A: [Taro-ga ki-ta] yo.
 Taro-nom come-pst YO
 'Taro has come.'
- Speaker B: **Mitai** desu ne.
 seem be NE
 'It seems to be the case.'
- Speaker B: **Kadooka**-wa wakari-ma-sen ne.
 KADOOKA-top know-plt-neg NE
 'I don't know whether he came or not.'
- Speaker B: **To** omoi-mas-u ne
 comp think-plt-prs NE
 'I think so.'

The contrast between (52) and (53) lies in the choice of particle that anchors PSE. In (52), the stranded universal quantifier *mo* arises from interphasal ellipsis. Saito (2017) analyzes Japanese wh-phrases as operators whose quantificational force is established via a probe-goal relation with particles such as *mo*. By contrast, particles such as *mitai*, *kadooka*, and *to* do not give rise to this problem, because the elided material in (53) is confined to a single phase.

I argue the contrast illustrated above stems from the structural positions of *mo* and *mitai*, that the former is the head of a functional head affixed to a finite relative clause while the latter is at least higher than TP. Specifically, Takahashi (2002) takes *mo* to be a universal quantifier base-generated with an indefinite nominal, such nominal may move to Spec, TP to acquire the nominative case, but stays within its local TP. An example like (54a) may have the structure in (54b).

- (54) a. Dare-mo-ga sitte-ir-u.
 who-MO-nom know.be-prs
 ‘Everyone knows it.’
- b.
-

As for the surface order in (52), Takahashi proposes that *mo* undergoes movement to the edge of the relative clause, which, together with the relative head, occupies Spec, TP of the matrix clause. It follows that the PSE in (52) deletes an interphasal string of the form [phase II [phase I C ~~dare-ga tukutta~~] ~~suupu~~ *mo*].¹¹ In fact, PSE involving the quantifier *mo* is licit in simple root clauses, where only a single constituent is deleted, thereby conforming to the no-interphasal condition (see Shibata 2014 for cases of non-quantificational *mo* in PSE)¹²:

- (55) Speaker A: Dare-mo kita-no?
 who-MO came-Q
 ‘Did everyone come?’
- Speaker B: Mo ki-masi-ta ne.
 MO come-plt-pst NE

¹¹I assume that Japanese relative clauses contain a (possibly null) C, as they can be paraphrased with an overt C head *toiu*. While *toiu* is typically associated with a reportative meaning, such a semantic contribution is largely absent in the context of relative clauses:

- (v) John-ga tukut-ta toiu suupu.
 John-nom make-pst C soup
 ‘The soup that John made.’

Crucially, *toiu* is not restricted to hearsay contexts: the speaker may use it even when the event is based on direct observation rather than reported speech.

¹²This part of the analysis is subject to revision pending a broader informant base, as all five of my native consultants judged the relevant *mo*-PSE to be “somewhat acceptable,” contrary to the judgment reported by Sakamoto and Saito (2018).

‘They did.’

By contrast, *mitai* in (53) yields an unproblematic instance of PSE. As for its syntactic status, Saito, H (2020, 2021) proposes that it is a functional head Mod that takes CP as its complement. This head should be included in Miyagawa’s (2022) expanded C-system, as it is anchored to a propositional domain. One piece of evidence provided by Saito, H is that *mitai* can follow an imperative, which typically occupies the CP domain:

- (56). Asita a-e mitai na hito. Saito, H (2021:123)
tomorrow meet-imp MITAI adn person
‘(a) person like (the) one who you should meet tomorrow.’

Pace Saito, H, Akimoto, and Tatsumi (2024), what is demonstrated in (56) does not involve the genuine modal *mitai*, but rather a prenominal modificational marker. They propose that the modal *mitai* used in PSE is a Mod head taking TP as its complement. Given that *mitai*, *kadooka*, and *to* are all higher than TP (see Uchibori 2000; Hiraiwa 2010; Law 2010), I argue that they all belong to the C-system proposed in Miyagawa (2022). If this analysis is on the right track, the material deleted in (53) constitutes a complete transfer domain, in contrast to the residual *mo* in (52).

A further important consequence of the present proposal is that, since it only rules out interphasal string ellipsis, the otherwise illicit standalone *yo* is expected to be rescued by the presence of *mitai* or *to*, which indeed appears to be the case (note that *kadooka* is pragmatically incompatible with *yo*), as shown in (57). The ellipses in Speaker B’s utterance are acceptable to the extent that they involve phase-local TP-deletion. The pattern in (57) thus provides further support for the argument developed in Section 4.2.2 that standalone *yo* involves ellipsis of its entire complement.

- (57). Speaker A: [Taro-ga ki-ta].
 Taro-nom come-pst
 ‘Taro has come.’
Speaker B: **Mitai** yo.
 seem be
 ‘It surely seems to be the case.’
Speaker B: **To** omoi-mas-u yo.
 COMP think-plt-prs NE
 ‘I do think so.’

Finally, I turn to two potential counterexamples to the present analysis. First, consider the ellipsis in (58), in which otherwise ill-formed *yo*-complement ellipsis is rescued by the presence of *ne*.

- (58). Speaker A: Hanako-wa kasikoi.
 Hanako-top smart

'Hanako is smart.'
 Speaker B: ʔYo ne.
 YO NE
 Intended: 'She surely is, right?'

All of my consultants agree that otherwise degraded instances of standalone *yo* in both SG and SR are significantly improved by the presence of *ne*. As discussed in Section 4.2.2, I have argued that the infelicitous *yo*-string deletion is attributable to interphasal string deletion. This raises the question of why *ne* ameliorates the problem. I propose (as noted in footnote 14) that, when *ne* is present and serves as the anchoring head for ellipsis, the relevant transfer domain is the complement of Addr. Consequently, the string TP–C–Spec, CP falls entirely within the phase domain of Addr, yielding a well-formed outcome.¹³

Another potential challenge comes from Mukai (2003), who argues that Japanese permits cross-conjunction gapping, as illustrated in (59):

- (59). Hanako-wa raion-ni, Taro-wa tora-ni osoware-ta hito-o tasuke-ta.
 Hanako-top lion-dat Taroo-top tiger-dat be-attacked man-acc save-pst
 'Hanako saved a man who was attacked by lion and Taro saved a man by tiger.'

According to Mukai, the deletion in (59) can be represented by the diagram in (60). In (60), the deleted string does not form a constituent, as it comprises the verb and part of a relative clause. I have proposed that Japanese relative clauses also contain a (null) C; it follows that such deletion necessarily spans multiple phases within the embedded clause.

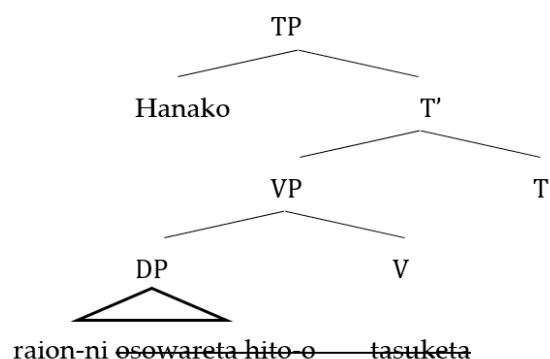
¹³ As the question mark in (58) indicates, *yo-ne* ellipsis, though substantially more acceptable than standalone *yo*, may still sound marked to some speakers. As illustrated in (vi), the presence of the copula *da* before *yo* yields a fully natural utterance:

(vi) Speaker B: (*Hanako-wa kasikoi) da yo ne.
 be YO NE

'I think so (I know she is smart).'

However, I argue that (vi) does not instantiate the same type of deletion as the standalone SFP cases. Unlike the examples discussed in Section 3.3, the phonetic content of Speaker A's utterance cannot be straightforwardly recovered in Speaker B's response. In fact, there is no syntactic position in which *Hanako-wa kasikoi* could be reconstructed in relation to *da*. A plausible analysis is that a silent pro-form (e.g., *soo* 'that') is merged before *da*, indicating that no PF-ellipsis is involved.

(60).



It should be noted that the finite verb *tasuketa* may be analyzed as a complex head consisting of V–v*–T in the sense of Distributed Morphology (Halle and Marantz 1993 et seq.). Crucially, the ellipsis in (60) would be interphasal if T is included in the deleted string. With respect to this issue, recall that the no-interphasal condition in (43) is motivated by considerations of computational efficiency: phase-spanning ellipsis would require the SM interface to access a previously checked transfer domain. As for (59), although the sentence is grammatical, it appears to induce a garden-path effect. The addressee initially encountering *Hanako-wa raion-ni* would incur additional processing cost in linking it to a distinct conjunct (e.g., *Taro-wa tora-ni ...*), which I take to reflect the underlying syntactic configuration responsible for the look-back effect.

Finally, Japanese CP-as-argument deletion does not constitute a counterexample to the present proposal. Consider the following sentence in which the sentential object of *omou* ‘think’ is deleted:

- (61). Speaker A: Taro-wa [Jiro-ga kaisya-o yame-ta to] omou.
 Taro-top Jiro-nom company-acc quit-pst TO think
 ‘Taro thinks that Jiro quit the company.’
 Speaker B: Watasi-mo *e* omou.
 I-too think.
 ‘I think so.’

The CP-deletion in (61) differs from the CP-deletion observed in standalone SFP constructions. The embedded CP in (61) lacks a superordinate expressive component (see Miyagawa 2022: 93); accordingly, the deleted portion does not correspond to a transfer domain of the Addr head.

Recall that I argued in Section 4.2.2 that standalone *yo* is illicit because the string preceding *yo* necessarily spans multiple phase domains (i.e., the C-complement and the C-edge). In contrast to standalone *yo*, the anchoring head for the ellipsis in (61) is the verb *omou*. Therefore, the actual transfer output fed to the SM interface is contained within the v* phase, and does not involve interphasal deletion.

4.2.4 Standalone SFPs are not pragmatics-triggered

It is tempting to attribute the difference between Japanese *ne* / SM *ga* and other particles in standalone SFP constructions to their pragmatic properties. *Ne* and *ga* are agreement/confirmation-seeking particles; accordingly, they are expected to be used in relation to another interlocutor's (or the speaker's own) prior utterance. By contrast, SFPs such as *yo* or *sae* serve to reinforce the speaker's commitment, and it is therefore pragmatically infelicitous to reinforce the commitment expressed by another participant in the discourse.

The pragmatic compatibility account, however, is unlikely to be on the right track. First, SG uses of *yo* also pose a problem, despite being pragmatically well-formed in the sense that the speaker merely reinforces their own commitment:

- (62). *Taro-ga tuku-tta suupu-wa oisii! Σ Yo.
 Taro-nom make-pst soup-top delicious YO
 '(I promise) the soup made by Taro is delicious!'

Note that the phonetic gap preceding *yo* is the culprit of the observed unacceptability, despite being expected to align with the pragmatic intention of the utterance. For this reason, I argue that the special properties of standalone SFPs must be accounted for in narrow syntax.

5. Concluding Marks and Implications

I have proposed in the present work that the so-called standalone SFP constructions in Japanese and Sichuan Mandarin can be analyzed in terms of PF ellipsis of the complement of such SFPs. Since this construction is attested across different types of SFPs, it must be subject to a licensing condition specific to a subclass of SFPs. Specifically, I tentatively argue that deletion of a phonetic string must be confined within a single transfer domain, thereby excluding interphasal string deletion. Under this proposal, the distribution of standalone SFPs receives a straightforward account: SFPs such as Japanese *ne* or Sichuan Mandarin *ga* are heads of AddrP, which is assumed to be a phase head; consequently, their complements can be fully elided, yielding standalone responses or gaps. By contrast, SFPs such as Japanese *yo* or Sichuan Mandarin *sae* are analyzed as non-phasal Commit heads, and deletion of the string preceding them (i.e., TP-C-Spec, C) would necessarily cross a phase boundary.

Besides standalone SFPs, the proposed phase-based analysis can also account for other types of PF ellipsis, such as VP-ellipsis and TP-ellipsis (sluicing). Japanese PSE involving deletion of more than one constituent is correctly predicted by the no-interphasal string condition; accordingly, C-type particles (including *mitai*, *kadooka*, and *to*) are compatible

with string-deletion ellipsis¹⁴.

As I suggested in Section 4.2, the no-interphasal string deletion condition formulated in (43) is not an exhaustive constraint on PF deletion. First, it cannot account for cases in which the elided material does not form a string, such as argument ellipsis (i.e., X^0 -level). Second, although the condition correctly rules out PF deletion that violates it, it may still permit ill-formed cases that nevertheless satisfy its formal requirements. Consider the following two deviant sluicing examples:

- (63). John bought something, but I don't know what.
(64)a. *John_i bought something, but I don't know what he_i.
b. *John_i bought something, but I don't know.

Sluicing proper in (63) can be analyzed in terms of an E-feature (Merchant 2001: 60): C is equipped with such an E-feature, which triggers deletion of its TP complement (a line of analysis that can also be extended to VP-ellipsis). By contrast, the absence of DP (argument) ellipsis in English is attributed to the fact that V—understood in recent minimalist approaches as a mere semantic root—does not bear an E-feature.

Note that the E-feature analysis correctly rules out (64b), since the functional head bearing the E-feature is itself deleted, whereas (64a) remains problematic in that TP is not fully deleted. Lasnik (2001, 2005) proposes that PF deletion is subject to constituency, which straightforwardly rules out (64a), as what is deleted there does not constitute a syntactic constituent (although many instances of PF deletion in languages such as Japanese appear to fall outside this generalization; still, Lasnik's proposal offers a potential solution to the undergeneralization problem faced by the present no-interphasal analysis, provided that apparent cases of non-string deletion are only superficial.).

Again, the present no-interphasal condition correctly rules out the phase-spanning ellipsis in (63a), but incorrectly permits (64a). In (64b), since the interphasal string TP–C–Spec, CP is targeted for ellipsis—on a par with *yo*-deletion—the condition in (43) correctly predicts its ungrammaticality. However, the ill-formed nature of (64a) must be accounted for by additional licensing conditions.

¹⁴ Particles like *yooni*, *koto* and *no* in Japanese block PSE, as pointed out by Fujii (2016), see (vii) for example:

- (vii) Speaker A: Taro-ga kaereru-yooni inotte-masu-ka?
Taro-nom come-back.able-yooni pray-plt-Q
'Do you pray for Taro to come back?'
Speaker B: *Yooni inotte-masu.
yooni pray-plt
Intended: 'Yes, I do.'

Note that Sato and Maeda (2019) analyze *yooni*, *koto*, and *no* as complementizers, whereas the present no-interphasal condition predicts that such cases should undergo ellipsis, contrary to their analysis. However, neither Sato and Maeda's proposal nor the present account provides a fully comprehensive explanation of the relevant data. This issue is left for future research.

Finally, the present account predicts that any particle merged in the SAP layer should, in principle, permit standalone realization. In addition to the Japanese and SM data presented above, Romanian *hai* (*haideți*, 2nd person plural), which is analyzed in Miyagawa (2022: 118) as originating as Commit head and subsequently moving to Addr, can also be used independently:

- (65). *Haideți, Tineri Titani!*
 SFP young Titans
 ‘Let’s go! Young Titans!’

What is shown in (65) is the Romanian translation of an American animated series, in which the presumed Addr head *haideți*, although occurring sentence-initially, exhibits a Standalone Gap-like pattern, with a possible deletion of a repeated *Tineri Titani* right after *haideți*.

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